



GAMO

HIGHLAND VILLAGERS OF ETHIOPIA

THERE ARE AROUND 700,000 GAMO PEOPLE in the highlands of southwestern Ethiopia. Their villages are dotted around the lush, green hills, and many are above 9,800 ft (3,000 m). Heavy rains fall from June



Family and friends

In the Gamo highlands, families live in compounds containing a number of huts. The main hut has a high, pointed roof so that rain can drain off the outside. Smoke from cooking escapes through the weave in the thatch. It can take five or six hours to cook dinner on the hearth at the back of the hut, so while women cook, men congregate to while away the time smoking and discussing local politics.

THE MAIN FAMILY HOME

The tall family houses are often 20 ft (6 m) or more, and feature a “nose,” or little porch at the front. The enormous bamboo poles planted outside this home signify that the man of the house is undergoing initiation as a *halaka*, or elder.

Bamboo grows abundantly and is important both for building homes and for rituals.

AN EXTRA ROOM

Frequently, simple round huts are built alongside the main family home. These are lower than the main hut and either house the family’s son and his wife, or are used for cooking or storing grain.



1 Making the walls
Making a hut is a lot like making a basket. Vertical lengths of bamboo are planted in the ground and then horizontal lengths woven through them to form walls.



2 The roof
A small round base, similar to the kind that forms the bottom of a basket, is woven, placed on top of the walls, and then connected to the wall struts.



3 Layers of thatch
Dense thatch is placed over the roof to form a thick covering that will prevent the rain from entering the hut. A hut like this one can last for several years.

